



Pratika's true utility, though, has been as Smriti's partner at the top of the batting pile. In 11 ODI innings, this duo has racked up 968 runs at an average of 88. The peak came in a record-breaking 233-run partnership against Ireland in January. Still, the bedrock of this pairing is nine 50+ run stands, which have set up India for competitive scores against its opponents.

Compare this with the Smriti-Shafali pairing, and the difference is staggering. **This duo has 909 runs in 21 innings, at half the average (45.45) and just eight stands of 50 runs or more.** Their brightest day was an unbeaten 174-run stand against Sri Lanka back in 2022, but it pales in comparison to the strike rotation and consistent consolidation challenges these two faced in both white-ball formats.

Shafali has tucked herself back into the shadows of domestic cricket, where her quality has repeatedly stood out as superior enough to amass runs rather effortlessly.

Pratika's consistency might make the journey back to the Indian team a bit harder for the imperious batter, in what is shaping up to be the biggest challenge of her career thus far.

India's opening efficacy has eased life for a middle order where better sense has prevailed in slotting players where they are strongest. When head coach Amol Muzumdar took over, experimentation was the name of the game as he moved his batters like jigsaw pieces. Jemimah Rodrigues floated in the middle order and Richa Ghosh was tried at number three, while other talents walked in and out of the playing XI in an effort to find who best meets the side's demands — a masquerade that frustrated more than comforted the India faithful.

However, this series has thrown up quite a few positives. Jemimah **(above, left)** had a series to remember, finishing with 245 runs in four innings, averaging 61.25 and striking at a healthy 117.78. Her ODI comforts have been a few years in the making, with a generous amount of soul-searching

« The improvement never stops though, such as areas like fielding, bowling and building good partnerships. Our medium pacers keep getting injured, so need to work on that. The team is working on that. But we're going to try and keep playing good cricket. There are a lot of positives to talk about, but just want to enjoy the moment right now — Harmanpreet Kaur »

involved in locking in her style of play.

"The confidence I have and, more than that, just me understanding my game (has helped me in ODIs)," Jemimah said after her match-winning ton against the Proteas. "Usually, I used to play four to five dot balls, get panicky, and throw my wicket. But now I think that a sense of calmness is there. I can make up anytime. A lot of T20 cricket has helped me," she added.

Over three WPL campaigns and fiercely contested bilaterals in recent years, Jemimah — and by extension, the team management — has learnt to trust her ability to switch gears as an anchor. Her strengths lie

in her impeccable timing and placement, and her ability to bore away at opposition bowlers by relentlessly picking the ones and twos. While pursuing boundaries has seen her become more audacious, this is a textbook player, essaying a textbook part to perfection. Her solidity allows Harmanpreet **(above, right)** and designated lower-order strikers like Richa Ghosh to play their natural game. It's a mould even someone like Sneha Rana — remember her five-ball 26-run cameo for RCB against UP Warriorz — is casting herself into.

Harleen Deol's starting trouble on the road-like pitches in Colombo is a point of concern, especially in the number three slot. Her 157-run haul came at an ordinary average of 39.25 and a strike rate crying for acceleration — 73.36.

Slow innings progression has